

119:89). If the word is in heaven, then it must be God's, and only an eternal Being could produce an eternal word. 1 Peter 1:25 quotes Isaiah 40:8, "the word of the LORD endures forever", and there are a number of further passages that say essentially the same thing. Again, only an eternal Being could produce an eternal word.¹

Matthew 5:18, "assuredly I say to you, until heaven and earth pass away, not one iota nor one tittle shall pass away from the Law until everything happens". Sovereign Jesus is making a statement about the preservation through time of the precise form of the Sacred Text. Only a maximum Authority could guarantee something like that. "All Scripture is God-breathed" (2 Timothy 3:16). Paul coins an expression to describe the intimate connection between God and His written Revelation; it is like His very breath.

Romans 14:24, "Now to Him who has power to establish you according to my Gospel and the proclamation of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery kept secret through long ages, but now revealed and made known through the prophetic Scriptures, according to the command of the eternal God, with a view to obedience of faith among all ethnic nations."² Since it is being revealed only 'now', these 'prophetic Scriptures' must be New Testament writings, given by God!

2 Peter 1:20-21, "knowing this first, that no Prophecy of Scripture comes to be from private release;³ for no Prophecy ever came by the will of man, rather holy men of God spoke as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit." Here we have an impressive description of the process of Inspiration. I like the definition of the Scriptures that we find in Romans 2:20—"having in the Law the embodiment of knowledge and truth". Who but the Sovereign Creator could produce a written Revelation that embodies knowledge and truth?⁴

¹ I have already referred to 1 Chronicles 16:15.

² 5.2% of the Greek manuscripts place verses 24-26 at the end of the book, rather than here. Paul habitually places doxologies throughout his letters—they do not occur only at the end.

³ The word rendered "release" occurs only here in the New Testament, but the basic meaning of the root is 'to loose' or 'release'. With reference to a prophetic word, it could refer either to its enunciation/origination or to its interpretation. Verse 21 makes clear that here it is the origination. False or fake prophecies derive from the will of the 'prophet' (or demonic influence), but true prophecy never does.

⁴ I take it that the declarations I have cited affirm the existence of a written Revelation, but they do not give us the identity of the inspired writings that make up that revelation, the composition of the Canon. I will take up that question in its turn.